

Building a home

The animal world includes some amazingly gifted builders. They make homes to protect themselves and, even more importantly, to shelter their young. Some animal homes could fit in a thimble, but the largest can be taller than a house and take generations to construct and maintain. All animals rely on inborn behavior called instinct to help

them assemble a new home using the right building materials.

Stately piles

Many birds build a new nest each spring to house their eggs and chicks, but bald eagle pairs reuse the same one for up to 20 years. Both partners help to repair their old nest high up in a tree by adding fresh supplies of sticks. After many years of construction, a bald eagle nest can be enormous. One of the largest ever found measured 20 ft (6 m) from top to bottom—as tall as a two-story house—and weighed nearly a ton.

Beaver lodges

Beavers build the largest structures in the animal world, aside from coral reefs. They cut down trees and branches and use stones and mud to construct dams across rivers and streams. Some beaver dams are more than 1,600 ft (500 m) long. These create a pond that surrounds and protects their family living quarters, or lodge, which is built from a huge pile of sticks.



Lodge roof covered with sticks and sealed with mud

Sleeping chamber above water

Underwater passage

Nest hangs from thin tree branch as protection against predators